

Tanuja, too, didn't mind taking the tube when it came to re-kindling her liaison with the camera. Her comeback as the feisty social activist Bimla Tai Kirloskar on 9X's "thriller comedy" *Babban Bhai Vs Bimla Tai* has been nothing short of a joyride for the 60-year-old. "Ultimately, it is all about communicating on a one-on-one basis with the audience. The medium does not matter," she says.

Probably why the evergreen Rajesh Khanna is taking the prime time plunge with a bi-weekly show,

COURTESY: RAAJA R. BUNDILLA



ZEENAT AMAN 56

After *Boom* (2003) bombed, she's all set for the release of *Dil Tau Deewana Hai*, to be followed by Nileish Malhotra's *Monopoly*.

Raghukul Reet Sada Chali Aayi, on DD1. Also on the cards is a TV project with Dheeraj Kumar's Creative Eye Limited. Says Kumar, "TV programming has grown from 1,500 to 1,800 hours a week in the past one year alone, and with new channels being launched, the numbers will multiply."

And now it looks like cinema, too, has thrown open communication lines. Films are increasingly offering old warhorses a wide variety of roles and

enough enticement to don the greasepaint and step into the limelight. *Apne* was a shot in the arm for Dharmendra, who prepared for his return to the screen like a new man, cutting down on drinking, doing yoga, and eating right. Now the family is planning four films with Vijeta Films. "I did a lot of wrong films over the last 45 years because I couldn't say no. Now I have controlled myself," he says. Even as Dharmendra played a retired boxer, a hapless romantic and a con artist in the space of one cinematic year, the ever-youthful

The comeback crowd has wised up in the choice of roles. Over the years, many second innings on the silver screen have fallen short of box office glory. Glam goddess Mumtaz's attempt at a comeback with *Aandhiyaan* (1989) bombed. Bihar superstar Shatrughan Sinha's return with *Aan: Men at Work* (2004) failed to make an impact. Actor-turned-director Bundella says, "While senior actors are tried and tested, a project can be a hit only when they are given the right roles and dialogues. Zeenat Aman can't play the protagonist she did 25 years ago."

Thankfully, instead of hair dye and heavy make-up, filmmakers are relying on realism. The wrinkles are not being ironed out, bald spots are not

being covered up and there's no hiding the gray hair. "One has to grow up with age. I am content playing characters that suit my age," shrugs Tanuja. And while Vinod Khanna jokes that his female friends are not very happy with his mustachioed salt-and-pepper avatar in *Mere Apne*, he feels it is important to mould oneself as per the requirements of the character.

Whether it is character roles or stellar author-backed appearances, most veterans insist they are in it more for the love of acting than to replenish their depleting coffers. While Jeetendra finds his reality rendezvous to be a welcome

change from sitting at home, Dharmendra says, "Showbiz is like my beloved. I have never thought of it as a profession." "Everyone wants to work and good roles are bringing them back into the industry," agrees Bundella. Even as the film industry opens up to new genres and TV draws in teeming talent, these old-timers are ready for a successful swing at a new innings. Sunset has turned into a new sunrise on Bollywood Boulevard. ■



MANDAR DEODHAR

VINOD KHANNA 60

Leela (2002) was well-received, but *Risk* (2007) went unnoticed. Now he is looking at mass appeal with TV show *Mere Apne*, Anjum Rizvi's film *Fast Forward* and Boney Kapoor's *Pokiri* remake.

Rishi Kapoor is now set to romance Rekha in Raj Kanwar's *Sadiyaan*, fending off several leads after *Pyaar Mein Twist*. Tanuja has been signed on to play grandmother in the Ajay Kartik-directed *Hawai Dada*, which co-stars Anupam Kher. Vinod Khanna has two films in the pipeline, while sex siren Zeenat Aman is gearing up for Nileish Malhotra's *Monopoly* and *Dil Tau Deewana Hai*, co-starring Raj Babbar and directed by Raaja R. Bundella.